

[Return to Search](#)

Dogon restudied

Author(S): Beek, W. E. A. Van

Document Type: Article

Original Page: 147

Culture (OWC): [Dogon \(FA16\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1979-1989

Coverage Date: 1979-1989

Place Coverage: Tireli, Bandiagara, Mali

Section Title(S): Restudy Of The Dogon: Some Results

The oldest man in the village serves as *hogon*, ritual officiant (Dieterlen 1941, Paulme 1940, Bouju 1984). Each clan has a similar figure (fig. 6). The ward, containing two or three clans, may have a shamanic priest (in the literature "totemic priest" [de Ganay 1942]), who officiates at a *binu* shrine on behalf of members. The function of healer or herbalist (*jòjòngûnu*) depends on knowledge only. The mask complex has its own specialists, among whom the *olubaru* are the most important. They are the ones who know the traditions and texts in the ritual language better than anybody else, having learned them during a three-month-long initiation at the time of the *sigu* festival. It is their duty to recite them at the funerals of old men. Women born during the *sigu* have a special function as "sisters of the masks" (*yasigine*) and in contrast with the other women they are not supposed to fear the masks. Finally, the castes of Dogon society—the two groups of blacksmiths, the leatherworkers, the drummers, and the *segèû* (makers of serving bowls for food)—have special niches in Dogon religion, such as the making and preserving of public peace. The same holds in a different way for the many collective joking relations that characterize intervillage and interethnic relations in the region (Paulme 1940).

198
[Special Languages](#)

554
[Status, Role, And Prestige](#)

564
[Castes](#)

575
[Sodalities](#)

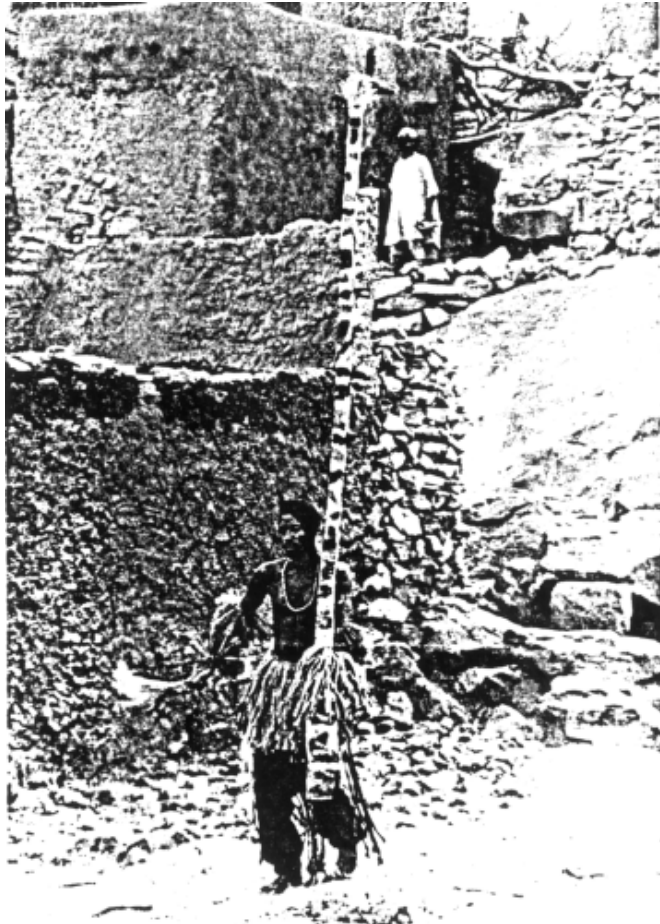
796
[Organized Ceremonial](#)

Summing up, Dogon religion is moderately intertwined with the ecological situation and changes in the social and physical environment, as it is with the social structure of Dogon villages and its changes. In general it has proved to be highly adaptable—incorporating new elements, addressing new problems and changes in status. The historical element is pertinent, as changes in the recent as well as in the remote past have found their way into ritual, but considerable cultural integration is evident in both the public and the malign, more secret, aspects of Dogon religion.

771
[General Character Of Religion](#)

This, of course, is just a sketch and does not do justice to the great internal variation within Dogon religion (a full-scale description is in preparation). It is obvious, however, that although much of the old ethnography is clearly still valid, there is a gap between my results and Graule's. The differences between his (later) data and mine entail a great number of ethnographic details, which may be subsumed in five statements summing up ■148

FIG. 5. *The "grand mask," the central object of mask ritual.*



what Griaule asserted but I could not replicate despite systematic attempts to do so.

184
Cultural Participation

292
Special Garments

342
Dwellings

5311
Visual Arts

771
General Character Of
Religion

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)